

The Season Planner & *fueling* sheet

Structure your year with training load — the way the Gran Diagonal was built.

This is the framework behind the 999 km, six-day crossing of Portugal: how to lay a season out as a system — a target, a ramp, a load per week, a taper — and how to fuel the big efforts. Two worksheets follow. Fill them in for your own A-event.

The five rules that make it work

- 01 Pick the A-day first, then count backwards.** A rough template: ~12–16 weeks base, 6–10 build, 2–3 peak/taper. Everything else serves that date.
- 02 Grow fitness slowly.** A rise in CTL of roughly **4–6 TSS/week** is sustainable for most trained amateurs; 8+ works for a short block but rarely holds. Ramp too fast and you don't pay day one — you pay in week three.
- 03 Bank a recovery week every 3rd–4th week.** Cut volume 30–40%, keep a little intensity. Fitness barely dips, fatigue clears, and the adaptation you already earned finally lands.
- 04 Most weeks sit just above your 6-week average.** That's the nudge that moves CTL up. Not every week a hero week — that's how ramps break.
- 05 Taper into form.** For the A-event, drop volume while keeping a little intensity so fatigue falls faster than fitness. Aim to arrive at a TSB of about **+5 to +25**: rested, not detrained.

Map your season

Set your phases first, then pencil a weekly TSS target for each week — nudging CTL up through base and build, easing in recovery weeks, and dropping into the taper. Your *weekly TSS* $\approx$ *daily average* $\times$ *training days*.

PHASE	TYPICAL LENGTH	WHAT IT'S FOR	WEEKLY LOAD
Base	12–16 wk	Aerobic engine, durability, strength	Steady, gently rising
Build	6–10 wk	Threshold & VO ₂ specific to the event	Highest sustained
Peak / taper	2–3 wk	Sharpen, shed fatigue	Falling, intensity kept

Your weeks

WK	DATES	PHASE	TARGET WK TSS	TARGET CTL	RECOVERY?	NOTES
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						
15						
16						

Tip: mark every 3rd–4th row as a recovery week before you fill in the loads — build the rest in first, then the work around it.

Fuel the big days

Six days across Portugal burned **~25,400 kcal on the bike** — about 4,200 a day. You never replace that. The job is to **minimise the deficit** so tomorrow's engine still starts. Here's what those days actually cost.

The Gran Diagonal — energy per stage (real files)

STAGE	DISTANCE	CLIMB	MOVING	KCAL (BIKE)
Day 1 • Gerês → Minho	153 km	3,247 m	7:31	4,502
Day 2	131 km	2,279 m	5:56	3,452
Day 3	142 km	2,439 m	6:15	3,788
Day 4 • Queen • Torre	183 km	3,191 m	8:15	4,774
Day 5 • Alentejo	222 km	2,767 m	8:57	4,945
Day 6 • to the Algarve	167 km	1,917 m	6:38	3,972
Total	999 km	15,841 m	43:32	25,433

On the bike

- Carbohydrate scaled to **stage length**, not appetite.
- Long mountain days: top of what you absorb per hour; shorter days a notch below.
- Carbs are the lever — at 6–9 h/day, fat can't cover the climb spikes.
- Drink to thirst plus electrolytes; heat multiplies the loss.

The moment you stop

- Carbohydrate + protein **immediately** — the window is real when you ride again in 16 h.
- Then a proper meal, then keep grazing to bedtime.
- Every gram in before sleep is fatigue you don't carry into tomorrow.

Read the drift

When heart rate at a given power creeps up across days, it's usually **under-fueling before it's lost fitness**. The fix is food, not heroics. Steady day-to-day HR at the same effort is the sign the load and the fueling are matched.

General guidance from one rider's data, not medical or individualised nutrition advice. Dial in your own numbers in training, never on the day.